Sometimes, the communiqué approval used to go through quickly and easily. But there were several occasions where it took much longer, often extending beyond an hour, in order to arrive at the language and nuance that all members felt comfortable with. It then became as much a test of English as of economic diplomacy.

I often wondered if the G20 meeting was degenerating into a communiqué-driven process with members focused more on messaging through the communiqué rather than on discussing and resolving the underlying issues. But I was in a minority. A majority seemed to feel that the prioritization was right: that putting effort into the communiqué was a productive use of G20 time given how crucial the communiqué was to shaping global sentiment.

Currency Wars

Two issues that regularly figured on the G20 agenda, either directly or indirectly, were currency wars and the dollar as the global reserve currency.

Although ‘currency wars’, as a phrase, is of relatively recent origin, and largely attributed to Guido Mantega, the former finance minister of Brazil, as a phenomenon, they have been part of international trade and finance ever since the 1980s when Japan had several run-ins with the US on the exchange rate of the yen against the dollar. Currency wars represent a situation when countries competitively depreciate their currencies against those of their trading partners so as to boost their exports and restrain imports, in a classic beggar-thy-neighbour attitude. Currency wars are ultimately self-defeating as they depress trade and raise the costs for all trading partners involved.

The origin of the latest round of currency wars lay in the ultra-easy monetary policies of advanced economies—zero-interest rates topped up by quantitative easing—aimed at reducing interest rates, stimulating domestic demand and helping economic recovery. In the event, this huge liquidity unleashed by QE found its way into emerging markets in search of quick returns. But emerging markets too did not have the capacity to absorb these